Not Waving But Drowning

By Erin McKean

Nobody heard him, the dead man,
But still he lay moaning:
I was much further out than you thought
And not waving but drowning.

Poor chap, he always loved larking
And now he's dead
It must have been too cold for him his heart gave way,
They said.

Oh, no no no, it was too cold always
(Still the dead one lay moaning)
I was much too far out all my life
And not waving but drowning.

INTRODUCTION

The poem you just heard is by Stevie Smith and sets the stage for the short story by the same name by Erin McKean. In McKean's futuristic world, technology has advanced to the point that a simple blood test can tell you just how you are going to die . . .not when, but how. What if your mode of death was Not Waving But Drowning by Erin McKean.

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Everyone knows that the fourth day of ninth grade is when you get your results. I mean, that's the way it happens in our town; other towns do it differently. But here, in our town, all the parents got together and decided that they just couldn't take knowing before we were at least in high school. Tim K. says it's because when you're in ninth grade, your parents find you so annoying that they can actually bear to think about you dying.

The way it works is pretty easy. The first day of ninth grade, in homeroom, the school nurse comes in and takes blood samples. She gives a ten-minute speech about the machine and how it works. (Short answer: nobody knows, but it's never been wrong.) She tells us that she's going to die in a fire. She doesn't even shiver when she tells us that—I guess when you've known for years and get up and talk about it every year, it becomes routine.

It's weird to see other people's blood. I watch the needle go in, careful not to look away. All the blood, each sample in a little barcoded tube, goes into one of those freaky BIOHAZARD mailers, and the nurse seals it in front of us. Of course it's all anyone can talk about. Helen wants to die glamorously, like in a terrorist attack. "Do you know how much money your family gets if you die in a terrorist attack?"

Naturally, we all hoot at this—there haven't been hardly any terrorist attacks at all, since the machine. There are still some every once in a while, in really poor places like India and Russia, where people can't afford the test, but it's hard to scare people about terrorism if they know they're going to die because they stuck a fork in a toaster.

It's hard to know what to wish for. Old age could be dying in bed, with all of your family around you, just like in a movie, with your daughter holding your hand and a room full of flowers, or it could be horrible Alzheimer's and being tied to a bed so you don't wander

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off, with no one there at all but you don't care because you can't remember anyone anyway. Car accident could be instant or it could be paralysis or amputation and infected bedsores that give you that staph they don't have antibiotics for anymore. Heart failure could be a dramatic heart attack, the fall-down-clutching-your-chest kind, or it could just be you get old, your heart stops. As I said, it's hard to know.

My mom and dad have the same one. Cancer. They met at a death party in college, where you got paired up with someone who was going to die the same way. They were the only two cancers at the party; by the time the machine came around most cancer was curable. Which sucks for them because they know they're going to have one of the bad kinds of cancer, like ovarian or pancreatic or brain, the really painful kinds. At least now when you get those kinds of cancer the doctors know you're going die from it, and they give you lots of painkillers. It used to be that it was hard to get painkillers, my mom told me. When her grandma died of breast cancer she was

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in lots of pain but the doctors wouldn't give her drugs in case she got addicted. That's because nobody knew she was going to die of the cancer. They thought maybe the cancer would go away and then they'd have an old lady addicted to morphine to deal with. That doesn't happen anymore.

My brother has just "accident," which freaks him out. It freaked us all out. Usually the machine is pretty specific. Car accident, household accident, whatever kind of accident. Just plain accident is pretty rare. For a while he went through what everyone goes through—the whole avoidy thing. He put grab bars in our shower. He walked to school, instead of riding the bus or his bike or driving.

My grandmas are both dead; one died before the machine, just had an aneurysm. The other grandma, my dad's mom…she was one of the first ones to use the machine in their town. Her ticket said suicide. My dad said she didn't tell anyone she was having the test. She

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just waited for all of them—my dad, his sister, his dad—to leave the house the next day, and then she took two bottles of sleeping pills. They didn't even know she had them; she got the prescription in another town and had been saving them. She didn't leave a real note. She just wrote "I'm sorry, I knew it" on her machine report and left it on the table.

My grandpa—her husband—he's never taken the test. He says that it's wrong to know, and that the whole human race is going to descend into mediocrity because of it. (He talks like that a lot.) He says that the fear of death, coupled with its unpredictability, is what drives humanity to achieve. He likes to talk about how there haven't been any real scientific advances since the machine. He says everyone is too busy spending time with their families and enjoying life to do any real work.

I don't really know too much about other people's tickets. Most people don't talk about it. It's hard to know what to say, when you find out someone's going to be shot, or hit by a car, or fall from a height. You either

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find yourself saying "that's not so bad" or you just talk about something else. It's kind of rude to ask someone that you don't know well. And since it's so vague, sometimes it's hard to know what to do.

Some people you do know how they'll die. Like, if they're famous. Famous people's tickets always get out. Someone they told will tell the tabloid pages—I've heard they pay a lot of money for famous tickets. Politicians have to disclose it. One guy who was running for governor in Tennessee faked his—his really said "shot by a hooker" and he got it to read "stroke." Of course someone sold that story. Now the politicians have to have their tests taken in public and read right there.

The day you get your results back there aren't any classes; you just show up for homeroom. They call you in one by one to another room to get your ticket, and then you just go home. Lots of people's parents take the day off. If they're really dorky they meet you at school. You can't really hang around after, although everyone's

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texting each other on their phones. Not asking, outright, just "U OK?" Lots of people don't talk about theirs, and that's cool. The teachers discourage it, for the most part, and sometimes your parents get mad if you tell somebody.

When they called me I felt a little nervous. Like, everyone knows they're going to die, but it's still a wobbly feeling to find out exactly how. My knees felt like they wanted to bend the wrong way, and I almost tripped getting out of my chair. I went into the room and sat down, and the counselor made me go through the whole routine. I had to tell him my social, twice. I had to do the iris-scanner, both eyes. I had to show him the waiver from my parents that allowed him to tell me without them present, and I had to sign a form allowing him to tell me, period, and releasing the test people from liability. Then I had to do the breathalyzer; a couple of years ago kids would show up wasted or high for their tests, so now you can't get the results unless you're sober.

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Finally he brought out my ticket. It wasn't in an envelope or anything, it was just the top one in his folder. The folder was black, which I thought was kind of weird. Like, why make the folder black? He was dressed in just regular clothes, tan pants and a blue shirt, no tie or anything, so the black folder just seemed kinda pretentious.

"You have a slightly unusual result," he said. That wasn't good. Unusual meant stuff like mauled by a bear, or electric-mixer accident, or choked on a pickle. Stupid stuff. Not dramatic or cool.

"Let me see." I really didn't want to wait. He pushed the ticket over to me. In block letters, it said NOT WAVING BUT DROWNING.

The man said, "It's a line from a poem." He held his pen like he didn't know what it was for.

"But it still means I'm drowning, right? It's not so bad."

"We'd like you to have the test retaken. It's unusual to get something

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like this. Something so…allusive." I looked at him. He hadn't done a good job shaving that morning; it looked like he used a real razor and not a depilatory laser. Maybe his ticket said he'd be killed by a laser?

"I don't know. I like this one. What if it changed to something worse?"

"That doesn't really happen. They don't change. Sometimes they get more specific—we think yours would get more specific."

"I think I'm good with vague, thanks. Vague and poetic is okay with me."

"Are you sure? You could retake now…" I noticed that he had a test kit, too, next to his chair.

"Nah. I'm okay." I put my ticket in my bag, careful not to fold it. Some people framed theirs, and kept it somewhere safe, especially if it was a cool one, like "saving a child." Mine was totally frameable.

"If you change your mind, here's a number to call." He beamed a number to my phone from his pen.

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"And we'd like your permission to keep a tracer on you, so that our department will be alerted when you die."

Wow—I was important enough to have a tracer? That was also cool. I couldn't decide if I'd tell anyone about the ticket, but I could definitely tell people I had a tracer.

"Sure, okay." He pushed another form to me.

"We have to let you think about this one for twenty-four hours, and your parents have to sign it, too. I have to disclose to you that tracer information is subpoenable, which means that if you are accused of a crime the data from the tracer can be used by the prosecution and the defense. You can drop off the form in homeroom tomorrow." He stood up, so I got up, too. He shook my hand. "I think you are a remarkable young woman," he said, like he didn't say that to everyone. "Please use this knowledge to focus and direct your life, and to live while you can." Then he recited the machine motto, *Dum vivimus vivamus.* Although nobody really

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knows Latin anymore, everyone knows that bit. It means "while we live, let us live."

My folks were home, and I think they had been crying. It's hard to think of people you love dying. Like they thought if they didn't know, I'd live forever or something. My dad gave me a big hug and kind of sniffled, before I even showed him the ticket, which was weird. I didn't really know what to say about the ticket, so I just pulled it out and showed it to them. "The guy said it was from a poem." My folks looked a little shocked, but then my mom just googled up the poem on the living room screen. We just stood there and read it, and clicked through to read about the poet. It was by somebody named Stevie Smith. She died of a brain tumor, which was as close as you could get back then to knowing for sure how you were going to die. Not a lot of people survived brain tumors. I kind of liked that she died that way. Not that she died, of course, but that she probably knew.

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The fact that it was a line of a poem: cool. The fact that I could get a tracer: cool. Drowning: not so bad. I'd heard it was peaceful. I pulled up the poem again and made it the background on my screen. I think I'll leave it there for a little while.

SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

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